

1251–55



Although not as sophisticated as Mayan hieroglyphs, Aztec pictographs such as the one shown could express simple concepts.

BY THE MID-13TH CENTURY, THE MEXICA TRIBE—better known today as the **Aztecs**—were established in the Valley of Mexico. Aztec legend suggests that they migrated from the ancestral homeland of *Aztlan* in the early 12th century. Settling at Chapultepec, near Lake Texcoco, Mexico, in around 1250, they were soon **expelled by the Tepanecs**, one of the tribal confederations competing for dominance in the wake of the **Toltec collapse** in the early 12th century.

Although the **Mongols** had conquered most of the Russian principalities (see 1236–40), and the **Golden Horde Khanate** had claimed authority over **Russia**, surprisingly little changed for the Russians. In return for tribute and military service, the Russian princes were left in power and the Russian Church was not interfered with. **Alexander Nevski** (c. 1220–63), the prince of Novgorod who had led the Russians to victory against the **Teutonic Knights** in 1242, became the dominant Russian noble, appointed Grand Duke of Vladimir after his brother was driven out by the Mongols.

Under the support of the new **Great Khan**, Mongke (r. 1251–59), his brothers Kublai and Hulagu renewed the **Mongol expansion**.

Prince of Novgorod

This statue depicts Russian leader, Alexander Nevski, whose name derives from the Russian victory at the Battle of the Neva River.

In 1253, Hulagu led a huge army into Western Asia to conquer the **Great Seljuk sultanate** (see 1031–40), while Kublai launched campaigns against the **Southern Song** and the **Kingdom of Nanchao** in China.



1256–60



This illustration of Mongols battling the Seljuks is from a chronicle by Rashid al-Din, a Muslim minister in the service of the Il-Khanate.

HULAGU KHAN (SEE 1251–1255) CONTINUED HIS CAMPAIGN AGAINST THE SELJUKS

and other Islamic powers. In 1256, he crushed the **Order of the Assassins** (see 1081–90), taking their stronghold at Alamut in Persia. In 1258, he sacked Baghdad and **executed the Abbasid Caliph**—the figurehead of Islam—in just one of countless atrocities committed by Mongol invaders who massacred hundreds of thousands of Muslims during their campaigns. In 1259, Hulagu penetrated deep into Syria, but as with Batu's campaign in Europe 18 years earlier (see 1241–45), his progress was halted by news of the **death of the Great Khan**, and he withdrew his armies while he returned to the Mongolian capital to help select a new leader.

Taking advantage of Hulagu's withdrawal, the **Mamluk** general **al-Zahir Baybars** marched north and struck at the Mongol garrisons in Syria. At the **Battle of Ayn Jalut** in Palestine, General Baybars **defeated the Mongols** and expelled them from Palestine and Syria. On his return to Egypt he murdered the sultan and took his place. Distracted by dynastic struggles, and later by a protracted inter-khanate war, Hulagu was not able to

KUBLAI KHAN (1215–94)



The grandson of Genghis Khan, Kublai spent eight years campaigning in southern China before succeeding his brother Mongke as Great Khan in 1260. His own kingdom, the Great Khanate, encompassed Mongolia and China, where he founded the Yuan dynasty, moved the capital to Shangdu, and did much to foster trade and international links.

regain his Syrian conquests and the westward expansion of the Mongol Empire was halted.

Hulagu's conquests, which encompassed Iran, Iraq, most of Anatolia, Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Georgia, became the **Il-Khanate**, or Ilkhanate. Meanwhile, the Mamluks gave refuge to a **fugitive Abbasid prince**, setting him up in Cairo as the **new caliph**. Recognized as guardians of the Islamic faith, the **Mamluks** were

formally made **sultans of Egypt, Syria, and the Levant**.

Alfonso X of Castile (r. 1252–1284) won the nickname “the Wise” thanks to his learning, patronage of the arts and Castilian literature, sponsorship of natural philosophy, and judicial reforms. He oversaw the final expulsion of the **Almohads** (see 1121–25) from Spain in 1257.

“HAD I BEEN PRESENT AT THE CREATION, I WOULD HAVE GIVEN SOME USEFUL HINTS FOR THE BETTER ORDERING OF THE UNIVERSE.”

Alfonso X, the Wise, on the Ptolemaic system

